



ETHIOPIA

Capital city: Addis Ababa**Area:** 435,184 sq miles
(1,127,127 sq km)**Population:** 70,700,000**Official language:**
Amharic**Major religions:** Muslim
40%, Christian 40%,
indigenous beliefs 15%,
other 5%**Government:** Provisional
government**Currency:** Ethiopian birr**Adult literacy rate:** 42%**Life expectancy:** 42 years**People per doctor:** 33,333**Televisions:** 5 per 1,000
people

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A LAND RICH in its own unique traditions, Ethiopia has in recent years suffered from drought, famine, and warfare. In 1984–85, a terrible famine, caused by a combination of civil war, drought, overpopulation, and overfarming, struck the northern highlands. During this time, Ethiopia was involved in a long, bitter war with the Eritreans, which only ended in 2000. Four out of five Ethiopians live off the land, growing crops such as *teff* (a type of grass) or herding cattle. Coffee is Ethiopia's major export crop. It is mostly grown in the mountains of Kaffa province, from which it gets its name.



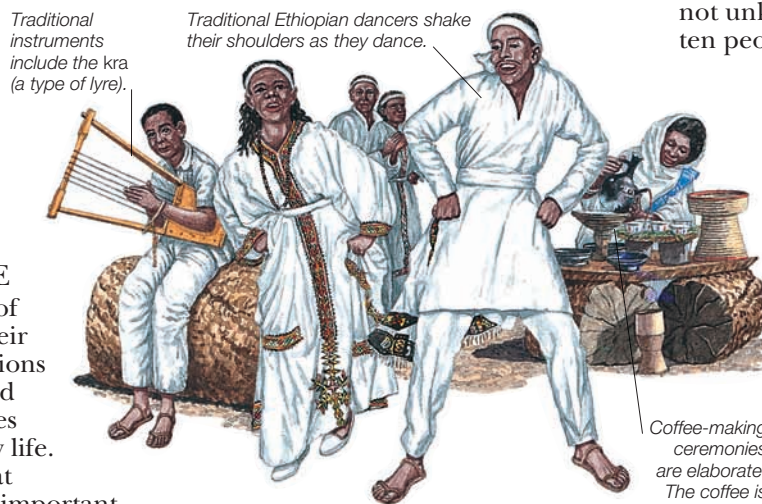
ADDIS ABABA

The capital, Addis Ababa, is the biggest city in Ethiopia, with some 4 million inhabitants. It is a rapidly growing city, home to many refugees from the north and Eritrea. Housing is in short supply and there are about 20,000 children living on the streets. Many people live in crowded slums without toilets or running water. It is not unknown for a family of eight to ten people to share one room.

MUSIC AND DANCE

There are many groups of Ethiopians, each with their own language and traditions in storytelling, music, and dance. Traditional dances tell stories from everyday life. The music and songs that accompany them are an important means of passing on information about local cultures and customs.

Ethiopian Orthodox priests at a religious festival in Addis Ababa



Traditional instruments include the kra (a type of lyre).

Traditional Ethiopian dancers shake their shoulders as they dance.

Traditional dress consists of an embroidered white dress and shawl for women, and white shirts and pants for men.

Coffee-making ceremonies are elaborate. The coffee is brewed with added spices, incense is burned, and grass spread over the floor.



FIREWOOD

Women are responsible for cutting, carrying, and selling firewood, a major source of fuel and income. Much of Ethiopia's forests have now been destroyed, however. This has led to the soil, no longer protected by trees, being blown or washed away and to the loss of valuable farmland.



Wot, made from red onions, chilies, garlic, ginger, and other herbs and spices, is added to meat and vegetable dishes.

A typical vegetable dish made from cabbage, carrots, garlic, and red lentils



Hard-boiled eggs are often eaten with the meal.

Chicken stew, made from chicken, egg, and red peppers

Enjera

Beef stew, made from beef, cinnamon, peppers, red chili, and tomatoes

ETHIOPIAN CHURCH

The Ethiopian Orthodox Church can be traced back to the 4th century. Its most impressive monuments are the 12th-century churches in the village of Lalibela, which are carved out of solid rock. The Ethiopian Church has similarities with other Eastern churches and some Jewish customs have been retained, but its colorful ceremonies and festivals have their own distinctive flavor.

FOOD

The national dish of Ethiopia is *enjera*, a type of soft, flat bread made from *teff*, eaten with a mixture of meat and vegetables. These are cooked in a hot, spicy sauce, called *wot*. Traditionally, the sauce is served on top of the *enjera*. Raw beef, served with hot spices and melted butter, is eaten at festival times.

Find out more

CHRISTIANITY: 274

CITIES: 17, 206

COFFEE: 50, 62, 66

SOIL EROSION: 55, 244